The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Oil prices surged and Asian **stockmarkets** fell as traders reacted to the war in Iran that began over the weekend. Brent crude, the global benchmark, jumped by 13% when markets opened, before being pared back. Stockmarkets in China and Japan tumbled in early trading. Shares in airlines were hit particularly hard. Thousands of passengers remain stranded in the Middle East because of airspace closures.

Israel carried out strikes on **Lebanon**, including on Beirut, the capital, after **Hizbullah** launched missiles at Israel. The Iran-backed militant group said its attack was in response to “repeated Israeli aggressions”. A senior Israeli official warned Hizbullah that it would be “fully responsible for any escalation”. The two sides signed a ceasefire in November 2024.

President Donald Trump plans to speak with **Iran’s** new leadership, according to comments he gave to the *Atlantic* magazine. “They want to talk,” he said on Sunday, though declined to reveal when a conversation would happen. Ali Larijani, a possible replacement for Ali Khamenei as supreme leader, said Iran would not enter into negotiations with America.

America's armed forces said three service members had been killed and five seriously wounded. They did not say where or how, but denied Iranian reports that missiles had struck the USS *Abraham Lincoln*, saying the strikes did not "even come close" to the aircraft-carrier. Mr Trump claimed American forces had sunk nine Iranian navy ships and "largely destroyed" Iran's naval headquarters.

Sir Keir Starmer said **America** could use **British** military bases to attack Iran. The prime minister claimed the decision would ensure the "self-defence of longstanding friends and allies". He added that countries in the Gulf had requested Britain's help, but insisted it would not take part in any attacks. Iran has launched retaliatory strikes on other countries in the region, including Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar.

In other news: Shabana Mahmood, **Britain's** home secretary, said that from Monday people granted asylum would be offered only temporary refuge in the country, and that cases would be reviewed every 30 months. A gunman in **Austin, Texas** killed two people and injured 14 at a bar; the FBI is investigating a potential connection to terrorism. And **María Corina Machado**, Venezuela's opposition leader, said she would return to the country in the coming weeks.

Figure of the day: $85bn, the value of venture-capital investments in European startups in 2025, up from $22bn a decade earlier. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

Hizbullah enters the fray

When American and Iranian officials met in January in Geneva for a last-ditch attempt at diplomacy, one of the many things they failed to agree on was Hizbullah. America and Israel wanted Iran to withdraw its decades-long support for the Lebanese militia. Iran refused. Ever since America attacked Iran on Saturday, people have been asking the opposite question: will Hizbullah support Iran?

Late on Sunday it provided an answer by launching a barrage of missiles at Israel. Hizbullah's decision to enter the fray could be deeply unpopular in Lebanon. The country is still recovering from Hizbullah's last conflict with Israel which, by the time a ceasefire was reached in 2024, had displaced more than a million people. That is partly why the group did not join the fighting when Israel attacked Iran last year. This time round, though, America and Israel have plainly stated that their intention is to dismantle Iran's regime. Confronted with this existential threat, it looks like Hizbullah's domestic political concerns will count for little.

Photograph: Getty Images

What’s next for the war in Iran?

It took American forces nine months to find and capture Saddam Hussein in 2003. The killing of Ali Khamenei took only a day. On Sunday morning, less than 24 hours after America and Israel first attacked Iran, news of the supreme leader’s death was being reported on state television.

But that does not mean the war itself will end swiftly. Iran responded by firing a barrage of missiles: hundreds at Israel and the United Arab Emirates; dozens at Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Oman and Saudi Arabia. Most were intercepted, but each successful Iranian strike increases the likelihood of a wider conflict. Israel’s interceptor stocks can hold for days, but probably not weeks.

Nor is there any clear sign that America and Israel’s actions so far will achieve their goal of dismantling the Iranian regime. The country’s security forces are still capable of suppressing mass unrest. And a government collapse creates new problems, including how to deal with Iran’s nuclear facilities. None can be solved quickly.

Photograph: Getty Images

Iran’s isolation is becoming evident

Iran’s regime has few friends to call on. The Islamic Republic is not popular in Europe, where many countries are calling for a democratic transition. It boasts of close ties to Russia, which recently conducted naval exercises with Iran, and China, which has reportedly sold the country air-defence systems. Both denounced America and Israel’s air campaign, but have stayed out of the fight

Gulf Arab monarchies, meanwhile, got no thanks for urging America to pursue diplomacy. Iran fired hundreds of missiles and drones at them—not just at American bases but also at civilian targets. Even Oman, which was mediating between America and Iran during their most recent nuclear negotiations, was struck.

That attack, in particular, seemed counterproductive. Iran’s foreign minister tried to do damage control, suggesting that Iran’s revolutionary guard corps, which answers directly to the supreme leader, was acting on orders “given to them in advance”. For Oman’s part, its foreign minister wrote on social media that “the door to diplomacy remains open”.

Photograph: Reuters

Congress confronts Trump's latest foreign intervention

When Donald Trump took to social media to announce the death of Ali Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader, he boasted of having achieved "justice" for "all great Americans". Democrats, unsurprisingly, feel differently. Most argue that American strikes on Iran contravene the War Powers Act of 1973—legislation meant to prevent presidents from unilaterally committing the country to an armed conflict without congressional approval.

Congress will now debate a resolution to rein in Mr Trump in the coming days. It is unlikely to pass: similar votes on military action in the Caribbean and Venezuela floundered. And most of Mr Trump's supporters in the House of Representatives have cheered him on in the Middle East.

But there are growing signs that some of the president's allies are also tiring of his penchant for overseas intervention. Tucker Carlson, a right-wing commentator, called the attack on Iran "disgusting and evil". Marjorie Taylor Greene, an ex-congresswoman and disenchanted former Trump loyalist, described it as the "worst betrayal".

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?

Peace means the ascent from simple coexistence to co-operation and common creativity among countries and nations.

Mikhail Gorbachev